

PACN 2026: Pagkakaisa

Full stageplay script extracted from the local DOCX source

Pagkakaisa

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by Angelica Baclig and Joshua Guico

Cast of Characters

KRYSTYNE-ANNE VERGARA: | 19 years old, college student

FELICIDAD BERZABAL: | 20 years old, college student

RAFAEL ADIONG | 20 years old, college student

JETHRO PAUL: | 19 years old, college student

MARC AGUILOS: | 25 years old, teacher assistant

FRANCISCO BACULANTA: | 42 years old, university advisor

MARIE REYES: | 29 years old, university professor

Place

Southern California University

Time

Late Winter (Spring Semester)

Scene 1 : FIST-201

Setting: | Outside in a university plaza. An A-frame sign promotes FiSt-201: Filipikno Studies—Dance Performances, with the Add/Drop Deadline clearly visible. Students pass through with backpacks.

At Rise: | JETHRO is walking back and forth on stage while on a phone call with his mom.

(iPhone Marimba ringtone plays while curtain opens)

Jethro

(on the phone)

Hey mom, sorry I missed your call earlier, I just got out of class. What's up?

(pauses, listening)

Oh, you're cooking tonight? What's for dinner? I have hip hop practice tonight, but if it's lumpia or chicken adobo, I'll definitely be there!

(pauses)

Dini-goo...what?

(clears throat, tries again)

Di-noo-gwan?

(attempts one more time)

Dinuguan? Mom, I've literally never heard of that dish, what's even in it? Is it like adobo?

(pauses, eyes widen)

(KRYSTYNE, RAFAEL, FELICIDAD enter from STAGE LEFT, acknowledge the sign and talks about it)
PORK BLOOD? And you think I'm gonna eat blood? Can't we eat something like...Jollibee or spam silog?
(pauses)

Okay, okay, fine, I'll try some—after all, who could say no to your cooking?
(pauses, sees KRYSTYNE, RAFAEL, and FELICIDAD approaching from STAGE LEFT)

Oh wait, my friends are here. We're about to go grab lunch at the dining ha-
(pauses)

Ugh, I know mom! I'll eat enough to "get big like Uncle Manny."
(FELICIDAD giggles)

I'll see you later tonight, bye bye.
(hangs up, turns to friends)

My mom is trying to make me eat pig blood for dinner.
Krystyne

Dinuguan! It's actually really good. My lola makes it all the time. Very...how would you say...visceral.
Felicidad

Krys, don't say "visceral" when talking about blood.
Krystyne

Why not? I'm a theater major, everything's visceral.
Rafael

(gently)
It's a Filipino staple, my tito usually serves it with puto.

Jethro
Yeah, well your tito probably didn't have to deal with his kid fainting at balut.
Krystyne

Okay okay okay, forget blood food for a second—we have some great news for you.
(excited, pulls JP toward the A-frame sign toward her STAGE LEFT)

Jethro
FiSt-201L Filipino Studies...Dance Performances?
Felicidad

It counts for the Cultural Arts GE requirement. And look-
(points)

Four spots left. One for each of us.
Rafael

Do you think Professor Baculanta is teaching the course? I heard she was interested in applying for the teaching position when the Filipino Studies campaign was underway last year, but she never confirmed if she actually applied.

Jethro

Oh you're right! I've heard that she's been working on the campaign for over a decade, long before we all started getting involved when we joined Sparta Philippines together last year.

Krystyne

Hmm, I'll check on InternetReg to see who the professor is-

(pulls out her phone and checks InternetReg)

Oh-

(surprised and confused)

Rafael

What's up? Is Baculanta not teaching the class?

Krystyne

No...she isn't. It's another professor named Reyes. Do any of you guys know who they are?

Felicidad

I've never heard of that professor before. I'll check on AssessMyProfessor to see if they're good.

(pulls out her phone and checks AssessMyProfessor)

Hmm...they don't have any ratings; This is probably their first semester teaching at Southern California University. Should we still take the class?

Jethro

I think we should. Like you mentioned earlier, we all still need to complete the Cultural Arts GE requirement, so why not take one about our Filipino identity?

Rafael

JP's right—with the add/drop period ending tonight, I think it's our best bet to take our chance with this class and professor.

Krystyne

Well! I'll take whatever anyone's saying as a sign, I'll enroll in the class right now.

(pulls out her computer)

Jethro

Me, too.

Felicidad Me, three. | Rafael Me, three.

(everyone pulls out their laptops and enrolls in FiSt-201)

END OF SCENE - BLACKOUT

Scene 2 : FIRST CLASS

Setting: | A transitional space between hallway and classroom. Two-thirds of the stage is the classroom (STAGE RIGHT), set with chairs, a whiteboard. And one table. One-third represents the hallway outside (STAGE LEFT), divided by a visible classroom door.

At Rise: | The classroom is empty. BACULANTA enters from stage right, carrying a folder and looking around the classroom with a mixture of pride and melancholy. She touches the whiteboard, adjusts a chair, then walks to the door and peers out into the hallway.

Baculanta

(exits the classroom)

Oh! Excuse me-

(recognizes them)

Ay, hello! Kryz, Raf, Ida, and JP! You're taking FiSt-201?

Rafael

Yeah! We enrolled yesterday. We thought you'd be teaching it, actually.

Baculanta

(beat, forced smile)

Ah. No, no. Professor Reyes is teaching this course.

Felicidad

Professor B, we know you applied. You've been working on getting Filipino Studies approved for like...ever.

Baculanta

(waves hand dismissively, but there's hurt underneath)

I wasn't sure about my availability this semester. But these things happen, you know? The important thing is that the class exists now, yes? Now hurry and go inside, the class starts soon!

(the students start walking through the door, JP being the last)

You'll tell me everything you learn, ha? And please...be open-minded. Give Professor Reyes a chance.

Jethro

Will do, Professor B. We'll see you around!

(nonchalantly salutes, BACULANTA waves bye)

(BACULANTA walks a little and stumbles upon REYES as she enters the STAGE LEFT)

Reyes

Professor Baculanta?

Baculanta

Yes?

Reyes

Marie Reyes. I'll be teaching the new Filipino Studies course this semester.

(reaches out a hand and shakes BACULANTA's hand)

Baculanta

Welcome to the University.

Reyes

I've heard a lot about the new program and the students seem very invested.

Baculanta

Of course! They worked hard to make it happen.

Reyes

I hope I can meet their expectations.

Baculanta

I hope so too... but of course that depends on what you teach them.

(laughs fakingly)

Reyes

Well... I suppose we'll find out. I'm surprised you're not the one teaching this course when the dean told me about your vast knowledge in sociology and you being the advisor of the Filipino club on campus.

Baculanta

Well, I do have a lot of research to finish up this semester, so I thought it's best not to overload myself. I will see you around, Professor Reyes.

Reyes

See you around Professor Baculanta.

(BACULANTA exits STAGE LEFT. REYES enters the classroom)

Reyes

Good morning, sorry I'm a bit late, but...welcome to FiSt-201!

(writes name on board)

I'm Professor Reyes, and over there is your teacher assistant, Marc!

Marc

(MARC waves)

Hi, nice to meet you all!

Reyes

We are both very excited, as this is the university's very first Filipino Studies class.

(everyone claps, beat)

(REYES smiles and reaches into her bag to get the student roster)

Since the program is so new, I've focused our curriculum on the most well-known dances—the rural and Maria Clara suites. Tinikling, Sayaw sa Bangko, Cariñosa—all the classics that really represent Filipino culture on a national level!

(RAFAEL's expression shifts—discomfort. KRYSTYNE and FELICIDAD exchange glances)

Reyes (Cont'd)

Let's take attendance, shall we? Amir Johnson?

Student 1

Here.

Reyes

Crystal-Anne Ver-GAY-rah?

Krystyne

(correcting)

Krystyne-Anne. Ver-GAH-rah.

Reyes

(quickly, not really listening)

Right, sorry. Felicity Ber-ZAY-ball?

Felicidad

Felicidad. BEAR-zah-ball.

Reyes

Oh, Feliz Navidad! Ra-fay-el Ay-DEE-ong?

Rafael

(flat)

Ra-fa-EL. Ah-dee-ONG.

Marc

(leans toward REYES and murmurs)

Ah-dee-ONG.

Reyes

(dismissive)

Sure. Jethro Paul ?

Jethro

(surprised)

Here.

(The friend group exchanges pointed looks, REYES got JP's name right but rushed through everyone else's)

Reyes

Alright! Let's dive in. Today: Tinikling, the most iconic Filipino dance.

(writes on board)

This dance started during Spanish colonial times and shows Filipino resilience. The bamboo poles represent Spanish traps, and dancers jumping between them shows how Filipinos adapted. The dance actually originated in Manila and spread throughout the islands from there.

Rafael

(politely)

Actually, Professor, I'm pretty sure Tinikling is from Leyte in Visayas.

Reyes

(waving hand)

Well, there are different theories. The Manila origin is one perspective.

Marc

(respectfully)

Some sources do cite Leyte in Eastern Visayas as the regional origin.

Reyes

(smiles and continues without acknowledging the correction)

The “tinikling” bird that inspired it lives in the rice fields-

Krystyne

(quietly to FELICIDAD)

Is she...is she just not listening to him?

[MARC pretends to organize papers but clearly hears and takes note of what KRYSTYNE says]

Reyes (Cont'd)

—and the Spanish would set traps for birds, which is where the pole-trapping motion comes from. The dance uses a traditional rondalla with guitars and bandurria, always in three-four time...

(her voice becomes monotonous, academic, droning)

The cross-step pattern requires precise timing...hop on both feet...the cultural significance cannot be understated...

(students begin to zone out. Not sleeping yet, but clearly disengaged. KRYSTYNE doodles. FELICIDAD stares at the ceiling. RAFAEL looks frustrated. JP tries to take notes but his pen slows)

Reyes (Cont'd)

(oblivious to room's energy, continuing to lecture)

...which is why we see this dance at every Filipino cultural event. It's the quintessential representation of Filipino identity...

Felicidad

(whispers to KRYSTYNE)

This is the same information we learned in elementary school.

Krystyne

(whispers back)

And she won't even acknowledge when Raf corrects her...

Reyes (Cont'd)

(still droning)

The performance requires two bamboo poles, each approximately six feet long...

Marc

(softly, attempting to engage the students)

Has anyone here performed-

Reyes

We'll discuss participation later. First, the historical framework. Anyways...two clappers and two dancers typically...the rhythm follows a pattern of Close-open-close-open-close...

(Lights begin to dim. Dreamy music fades in. Now, the

students start actually falling asleep—heads nodding,

eyes closing. REYES's voice echoes and fades.)

[TRADITIONAL TINIKLING PERFORMANCE - in dream sequence. Performance happens in soft, dreamy lighting as students sleep at desks.]

BLACKOUT

(Lights up. Students wake up groggy. REYES is finishing her sentence, unaware anyone slept.)

(checks watch, alarm rings)

Reyes

Perfect timing. That's the cultural significance of Tinikling! Before next class, please read the fifty-page packet on Sayaw sa Bangko. Please pick it up at the door with Marc before you leave. See you then!

(REYES exits cheerfully. STUDENTS pack up slowly, disoriented.)

Rafael

(frustrated)

Did you hear her? "Manila origin"? That's completely wrong. And when I corrected her, she just dismissed it.

Krystyne

She wasn't even engaging with us. Just talking at us.

Felicidad

There wasn't anything new.

Jethro

(trying to be positive but uncertain)

Maybe...maybe it'll get better? It's just the first day.

Rafael

(quietly, bitter)

Still, she's teaching us our own culture and getting it wrong. And she won't even listen when we correct her.(i feel this is redundant)

(STUDENTS approach MARC to get their Sayaw Sa Bangko packets.)

Marc

(handing out a packet for each student)

Hi, I want to say something—but I need to be careful about what I say.

(beat)

You're not wrong.

(beat)

Leyte is the most widely accepted origin. And there are multiple scholarly sources that support that. If you're going to challenge something in class, bring citations. Bring documentation. That shifts the conversation from opinion to academic discourse.

(beat)

Also...Filipino culture isn't monolithic. It isn't just what was preserved in state-sponsored cultural programs in the 1970s. There are regional histories, oral traditions, and community archives.

(softly)

And those deserve to be recognized too.

(The students look at him surprised)

Krystyne

So...you agree with us?

Marc

I agree that accuracy matters. And I agree that students who come from the culture shouldn't feel dismissed when they speak.

(beat)

Just...be strategic.

(beat)

I'll see you all next class.

(He gathers his stuff and exits separately stage left)

(The students exit. Their energy is noticeably deflated. Lights fade)

END OF SCENE - BLACKOUT

Scene 3 : THE LIBRARY

Setting: | The university library. The space is mostly open, suggesting a study area. Several wooden benches are pushed upstage as "study benches"

At Rise: | A couple is sitting on a bench in the library (stage right).

[Spotlight on CAI and JANTZEN (stage right)]

Cailin

Wait—my midterm exam was actually not that bad earlier. I think I did pretty okay!

Jantzen

That's amazing, babe! I know how hard you have been studying for your Intro to PR midterm. But since it's Valentine's Day I do have a surprise for you before we go out to eat.

[TROY PHI VOICES (TPV) - PERFORMERS COME IN STAGE LEFT]

Cailin

(once music starts)

Oh my goodness, you shouldn't have-

(with a puppy face expression)

[Lights only on TPV]

TPV PERFORMS "JUST THE WAY YOU ARE" BY BRUNO MARS

[Lights only on couple]

(Friend group moves into stage left while the spotlight is on couple)

Jantzen

I hope you liked my little surprise, especially after a hard week of studying.

Cailin

I loved it! I've never been surprised like that before.

(kisses JANTZEN on the cheek)

Jantzen

(grabs CAILIN's bag next to her)

Are you ready to go to dinner? I would hate to run on Filipino time for our reservation.

Cailin

Yes, I am.

(grabs JANTZEN's hand and walks off stage)

[Lights all on]

Felicidad

Ugh! I love, love!

Rafael

Yea, so cute... I mean the song!

Krystyne-Anne

Ugh! That was like watching a Kathryn Bernardo and Daniel Padilla movie...makes me feel so single.

Jethro

Alright now, you don't have to announce to the world that you're single. Let's get started with the reading?

Rafael

Yea I guess. We already know about the history of Sayaw Sa Bangko, but I guess we have to relearn it anyway...

(sighing and shoulder shrug)

Jethro

(opens up his packet, confident)

Let's start on page 2: "Sayaw sa Bangko is a traditional Filipino folk dance believed to have originated in the province of Batangas in Luzon during the early 1970s. The dance was supposedly created as part of a nationwide cultural revival movement in 1975, when metal benches became widely available and were introduced as the primary prop."

Krystyne-Anne

(confused, finishing the sentence)

"Historically, it was first performed during funerals in honor of deceased local government officials before eventually becoming a staple presentation at Christmas festivals in Manila-"

Rafael

Wait a minute...all of this information is wrong. First of all, Sayaw sa Bangko is from Pangasinan—not Batangas.

(angry)

Second, it originated during the Spanish colonial period.

(getting angrier)

And third-

Felicidad

(interrupting)

It's supposed to be performed at fiestas and community celebrations—not for funerals or during Christmas. It's too cold for Christmas!

Jethro

Wait. I highkey find this boring, can we just try to do the jumps they're doing in the pictures?

(stands up and get on the chair)

Rafael

JP, get down from there, we're in the library.

(JP gets down from chair)

And also this is the wrong kind of chair, we should be using a wooden bench.

Krystyne-Anne

Who cares? I bet a bunch of these people "studying" are just watching their favorite Netflix show. A chair is still a chair! JP, come here and help me.

(stands on the chair and grabs JP's hand. KRYSTYNE jumps from one side of the chair to another)

Oh my that's actually pretty hard, I'm kinda tired now.

(both KRYSTYNE and JP sit back down on their original chairs)

Felicidad

Well...if you were using the right type of chair maybe it wouldn't be so hard.

Rafael

You guys, it's been a long day, I just want to go home. I say we can read this individually?

Krystyne-Anne

Yeah, let's call it a night. I feel like all of this could have been avoided if Baculanta was teaching the class instead of Reyes.

(everyone closes their books looking tired)

[Light only shines on friend group]

Felicidad

Yeah, I second that. And I'm PRETTY SURE Raf can third that too.

(RAFAEL nods and then shrugs)

JP?

Jethro

(looks at watch/phone)

Hmm...I'm actually running late to practice. I'll see you guys later!

(JP stands up and fast walks off stage)

[Stagehands remove table and Sayaw sa Bangko performers walk on from STAGE RIGHT and are in first formation]

SAYAW SA BANGKO PERFORMANCE

END OF SCENE - BLACKOUT

Scene 4 : POP QUIZ

Setting: | The classroom.

At Rise: | The final beats of Sayaw Sa Bangko music fade out. The lights shift back to full classroom lighting. Students are seated.

Reyes stands at the front of the room. Marc stands to the side with a jar.

Reyes

Okay, so that was the video I wanted to show all of you guys showcasing Sayaw Sa Bangko. Does anybody have any questions?

All of friend group

No.

(shakes head)

Reyes

Okay in that case...pop quiz time. I hope you guys have read all the pages of the Sayaw Sa Bangko packet. This will be a verbal class quiz, and I will randomly pick names from the jar Marc is holding.

(points at jar)

Let's get started! Where did the dance originate from?

(puts hand in jar and pulls out a paper)

Krystyne-Anne?

Krystyne-Anne

Oh that's an easy one! That would be Pangasinan, professor.

Marc

That's ri-

Reyes

(interrupting)

Wrong! Sayaw sa Bangko actually originates from the Batangas province.

Marc

Professor, I'm not entirely sure that is correct. I distinctly remember the dance originating from Pangasinan when I went on my study abroad over the summer.

(REYES pulls up packet and goes through it)

Reyes

Hmm... I can accept that. BUT it is written in the packet that it originated from Batangas. So that is incorrect Krystyne-Anne.

(points at specific page on packet)

Okay. Next. What is the English translation of Sayaw Sa Bangko?

(puts hand in jar and pulls out a paper)

Felicidad?

Felicidad

Well, the literal translation is “dance on a bench.” It reflects agility and balance, and symbolizes trust between partners.

(looks over at RAFAEL, he smiles)

Reyes

Incorrect again. In the context of our reading, it metaphorically means “dancing through life’s obstacles.”

Rafael

This is all wrong.

(muttering under his voice frustrated)

Reyes

Well, Rafael. Since you seem so eager, in what settings was the dance traditionally performed?

Rafael

At fiestas, harvest celebrations, community gatherings. It’s not necessarily ceremonial in a mourning sense—it’s communal.

Reyes

(checking the packet)

It says here in the packet that it was first performed during funerals for local officials.

Marc

(being very careful with his words)

Professor Reyes, I think the confusion might be coming from the supplemental reading. That article has been widely critiqued for all of its inaccuracies. There are community-based scholars from Pangasinan who-

Reyes

Thank you, Marc. I really appreciate your enthusiasm and insights. However, I designed this curriculum very intentionally. All of the readings on the syllabus have been fact-checked by me.

(beat)

Moving onto the last question...

(puts hand in jar and pulls out a slip of paper)

Jethro—what type of props do they use in Sayaw sa Bangko?

Jethro

According to the packet, the props the dancers use are metal benches!

Reyes

(smiles)

That is correct! Thank you Jethro. Excellent reading comprehension.

(RAFAEL looks betrayed but says nothing)

Rafael

(raises hand)

Professor, may I use the restroom?

Reyes

Yes, go ahead.

[Light only shine on hallway (stage left)]

(RAFAEL exits the classroom through the door frustrated. He walks into the stage left and runs into BACULANTA)

Baculanta

Huy! Raf, shouldn't you be in FIST-201 right now?

(checks her watch)

Rafael

Yea Professor B, but I just needed to cool down a bit. I don't think this class is for me. I'm being taught wrong and different information from what I previously learned. It's been frustrating and confusing because Professor Reyes doesn't take corrections lightly. I was also hoping to delve deeper into other NON-mainstream Filipino dances. All we learn are the mainstream dances that "everyone" knows already.

Baculanta

My goodness, that does sound frustrating. Have you told Professor Reyes how you feel?

Rafael

No. Because every time anyone speaks—except Jethro for some odd reason—she brushes it off.

Baculanta

Don't give up! Y'know, you're setting a great example by fighting for proper representation. Maybe ask her about the possibility of *broadening* the scope of the syllabus. You could offer to present with sources or talk about lived experiences, including your own.

Rafael

Hmmm... You're onto something Professor B. Thanks for the talk, I think it's time for me to go back in there.

(points to the door)

Baculanta

Of course Raf. Lagi akong handang tumulong - I'm always ready to help.

[Light only shine on STAGE RIGHT classroom]

(RAFAEL walks through the door and into the classroom, sits down and raises his hand)

Rafael

Professor Reyes, may I suggest something?

Reyes

Of course, Rafael.

Rafael

I appreciate learning about Tinikling and Sayaw sa Bangko. But I think Filipino dance isn't limited to the rural and Maria Clara dances. For example—Singkil is from Mindanao and is a performance that is before colonial influence and represents royal courtship traditions. If possible, I'd like to present on it, so our curriculum reflects more than just the most commonly performed dances.

(beat, the room is silent)

Reyes

(slightly defensive)

Singkil is often performed by the Bayanihan Dance Company, yes. But this course is structured around foundational dances that represent the national identity.

Rafael

(with control, but intensity)

But whose version of “national identity”? The one filtered through colonial frameworks? Or the one that includes Muslim Filipinos, Indigenous communities, and regional histories?

(murmurs from class)

Marc

(carefully supportive)

Expanding the syllabus could enrich the academic rigor of the course.

Reyes

(voice tightening, looking at MARC)

The syllabus was approved by the department. We cannot deviate every time a student has a preference.

Rafael

It's not preference. It's inclusion.

(silence, the tension peaks)

(alarm rings)

Reyes

Class dismissed.

Krystyne-Anne

Ahhhh my theater class is across campus, I might be late. I gotta catch up with you guys later.

(KRYSTYNE rushes out of the classroom with a lot of things in her hand, she then exits stage left)

(FELICIDAD, RAFAEL, and JP wave bye)

(FELICIDAD and RAFAEL exit into the hallway and then stage left looking defeated. JP approaches REYES hesitantly. MARC remains nearby, listening)

[Light is only shining STAGE RIGHT on JP and REYES]

Jethro

Professor, I just...wanted to explain something. My friends—they're not trying to attack you. They were just disappointed. A lot of us thought Professor Baculanta would be teaching this class. She's been advocating for Filipino Studies for years. They're just...frustrated. That's all.

(REYES goes very still)

Reyes

I see.

(beat, a subtle shift in her expression, like something stored away)

Thank you for clarifying, Jethro.

(JP nods politely)

(MARC watches this carefully, sensing consequences)

Jethro

See you next class Professor Reyes.

(JP walks out of the classroom and exits stage left)

Marc

Professor...May I say something?

Reyes

(while packing her bag)

Yes, of course.

Marc

I don't think Rafael was trying to challenge your authority. Please see it as him being very passionate about the material. He is one of the main students advocating for this course along with Professor Baculanta.

Reyes

(stops packing briefly)

Passion is admirable. But a classroom cannot function if every student decides the syllabus is open for debate.

(looks at MARC)

Marc

I completely understand that structure is important. But these questions and suggestions from the students come from a place of investment. These students fought for Filipino Studies to exist here. When students see gaps in their curriculum, they just want to help fill them.

Reyes

(resumes packing)

And I appreciate that enthusiasm. But again, the syllabus was approved by the university. There are expectations I must meet and with that said, I do have to stay strict.

Marc

(nods in defeat)

I understand. See you next class Professor Reyes.

(RAFAEL and FELICIDAD enter STAGE LEFT)

(Exits through the classroom door and exits stSTAGE LEFT)

[Light only shines STAGE LEFT on hallway]

Felicidad

Hey, I know it got kinda heated in there, are you okay?

Rafael

(voice steady, frustrated)

I definitely could be better, just...frustrated. I'm tired of Professor Reyes being so close minded.

If only she was OPEN to including ALL aspects and eras of Filipino culture, then all of this conflict could've been avoided. Take Singkil, for example. Yes, it strays away from her "syllabus" but it encompasses underrepresented history and a holistic view of our culture. It's not just bamboo poles and fans. It tells the story of a Princess navigating an

earthquake in the forest—a test of grace, strength, and destiny. It is our culture. It is representation. It is Mindanao.

(lights quickly go out)

(Singkil music starts and the lights start to slowly brighten as they enter)

SINGKIL PERFORMANCE

END OF SCENE - BLACKOUT

Scene 5 : PROFESSOR TENSIONS

Setting: | An academic office. On BACULANTA's desk: a folder labeled "FiSt-201 Curriculum Proposal – F. Baculanta."

At Rise: | BACULANTA sits alone at her desk (middle stage), staring at the proposal folder. She gently traces the label with her finger. A knock at the door.

Baculanta

Good afternoon, please come in.

(REYES enters. She carries herself with professional sharpness.)

Reyes

Professor Baculanta.

Baculanta

Marie, no need for the formality— call me Francesca.

Reyes

Thank you, Francesca. I won't be too long.

(sits down)

(beat)

Something happened in FIST-201 today.

(fakes laugh)

Baculanta

Hmm. And what exactly happened?

Reyes

Rafael Adeong talked back to me in class, claiming my curriculum was lackluster. And then Jethro Paul told me the students expected you to be the one teaching the course. So, I'm just trying to understand something here.

(looks at BACULANTA)

Did you have anything to do with that?

Baculanta

Well, I did speak to Rafael.

Reyes

Against my class?

Baculanta

No, about how to express HIS concerns clearly. I only advised him on how to advocate for himself.

Reyes

It felt like he was testing my authority.

(BACULANTA doesn't immediately respond)

Baculanta

Your authority might always be tested, especially when the class involves identity.

Reyes

This isn't about identity. It's about the class I built with frameworks that have been reviewed and approved.

Baculanta

Approved by whom?

(REYES pauses)

Reyes

By the University. By other institutions that have preserved Filipino culture in an academic setting.

Baculanta

Or by institutions that decided what was worth preserving?

(beat)

(tension tightens)

Reyes

I am not erasing anything.

Baculanta

I didn't say you were.

Reyes

That's what you're implying.

(beat)

Why does it feel like I walked into a classroom that was already yours? Like every student in that room is waiting for me to fail so you can be proven right.

Baculanta

That is not what this is-

Reyes

Then what is it?

(stands up and knocks on the table)

Because from where I'm standing, it looks like you built this program, and because I'm not you, your students are challenging everything I do.

(sits back down)

(silence)

Baculanta

Do you want to know why I didn't get the position?

They told me I was “too political.”

(beat)

I included Mindanao.

I included Indigenous histories.

I refused to simplify things that made the University uncomfortable.

(beat)

Since I was being “too political”, they chose someone who would make it easier.

Reyes

(REYES stiffens)

What do you mean easier?

Baculanta

I mean someone who wouldn't challenge what they expect of the program.

(silence)

Reyes

When *I* got hired, they said, “Make sure the class succeeds. Do not let it become too political.”

(leans forward and taps the table)

So I built something that wouldn't immediately raise concerns. Because I am AWARE of what's at stake. We need this class to continue for Filipino students.

So when your students walk in and start tearing apart my syllabus-

Baculanta

They are not tearing it apart-

Reyes

(interrupting, louder)

They are questioning everything like I'm not Filipino enough to teach it.

(beat)

(silence)

Baculanta

That is NOT what they are saying. But it looks like you are teaching a version of the class that does not include them.

Reyes

I am teaching what was approved.

Baculanta

You are teaching inaccuracies as a result of conforming to the university's expectations.

(beat)

Marie...your students are not trying to take your authority from you. They are trying to see themselves in what you are teaching.

(beat)

And when they don't, of course, they're going to be upset.

Reyes

(with a lot of anger)

I am teaching what will keep this program alive!

Baculanta

Alive for who?

Reyes

For everyone!

Baculanta

No. For a flawed institution.

Reyes

If I lose control of that classroom-

(voice tightens)

They will shut this program down.

(beat)

Everything that you and the students built will disappear.

Baculanta

And if you continue like this-

(stands up)

With no openness-

Then the students will end this class with no added knowledge. They'll hate the class that they were supposed to help make happen. What you claim to stand for will mean nothing.

Reyes

I didn't take this job to erase anyone or anything.

Baculanta

Then stop teaching what doesn't accurately represent them.

(REYES shakes her head as she looks at BACULANTA and exits the office)

END OF SCENE – BLACKOUT

Scene 6 : PICNIC

Setting: | Outdoor picnic underneath a large tree. Late afternoon.

At Rise: | Raf and Ida sit on a picnic blanket (midstage)

CARIÑOSA PERFORMANCE

BLACKOUT

Felicidad

(warmly, comforting)

This weather is so perfect for a picnic. After a week of clouds and rain, the sun is finally out!

Rafael

Ida, thanks for planning this; it really means a lot after all the stress I've had with FIST-201.

Felicidad

Of course! I just wanna make sure that you're doing okay. I've known you for so long and I know it takes a lot to push you off the edge like that.

Rafael

Hahaha I see someone has been keeping track of my habits...

Felicidad

Alright now... no need for all that!

(the tone shifts)

Raf... I know things have been hard. I just wanted today to feel light.

Rafael

You always do that. You make things lighter.

Felicidad

On the other hand, though, I wanted to bring something up to you.

Rafael

What is it?

Felicidad

Well, I've seen how passionate you get about wanting to learn about ALL aspects of our culture, but... I just wanted to offer a new perspective about the "mainstream" Filipino folk dances.

Rafael

Okay...let me hear you out.

Felicidad

Well, La Cariñosa, for example, comes from the Maria Clara suite, which is, like the Rural Suite, one of the more popularly-known suites. Despite it being "mainstream", Carinosa's cultural significance and historical depth shouldn't be overlooked as "basic knowledge". Is what I'm saying making sense?

Rafael

Yeah, I'm starting to understand. Just because something is popular doesn't mean it lacks depth.

(beat)

Felicidad

Exactly. Our culture is layered. Colonial history is part of it too. Even something like La Cariñosa—with the handkerchief hiding the face—speaks to vulnerability. There's playfulness, but there's also distance. Longing.

Rafael

Longing?

Felicidad

(she noticeably looks away while talking)

Yeah. It's wanting to step closer... but being scared to. So you hide a little. You pretend it's just a dance.

(she looks at him)

We've been doing this forever, haven't we?

Rafael

Doing what?

Felicidad

Showing up for each other like it's nothing.

Rafael

Because it is nothing. It's just us.

(FELICIDAD studies RAFAEL)

Felicidad

Is it?

(silence, RAFAEL looks at her differently now)

Rafael

You remember when we were kids and you said love was supposed to feel like magic?

Felicidad

You said magic wasn't real.

Rafael

I was wrong. I tried to keep our friendship, I didn't want to mess up what we had. But all this time - I felt magic. I wanted us to be more than friends.

(offers his hand, she hesitates—then takes it)

Please don't let go.

Felicidad

You'll always have me Raf, whether it's as friends or more.

(beat)

Raf? Can you please play for me like you used to?

Rafael

Of course.

(stands up and grabs his guitar. RAFAEL helps FELICIDAD get up and starts strumming playfully. RAFAEL starts strumming MAHIKA and starts singing the song)

TPV PERFORMS MAHIKA

(Rafael starts and all of TPV comes in after)

(after their duet at the end, RAFAEL and FELICIDAD walk back near the picnic blanket holding hands)

Felicidad

So...magic, huh?

(while talking, RAFAEL lets go of FELICIDAD's hand and they both sit down on the blanket)

Rafael

Ida, I've liked you for a long time.

(she exhales—almost a laugh, almost a cry)

Felicidad

Raf...that took you long enough.

(they both laugh. they start to take out some snacks and the last thing is a handkerchief)

Rafael

(motions the handkerchief in his hands)

So no more hiding behind the handkerchief?

Felicidad

(smiling grabbing the handkerchief and putting it back in the picnic basket)

No more hiding.

Rafael

Guess we've been dancing around each other for years.

Felicidad

Guess we finally got the timing right.

(JP runs on stage from STAGE LEFT behind KRYSTYNE AND RAFAEL with KRYSTYNE right behind him)

Krystyne

(talking out of breath)

JP, I swear if you make me run another lap-

Jethro

-It's called conditioning Krys!

(they slow down a few feet away from the picnic blanket)

Wait...Krys. Stop.

(waves his hand to stop)

Krystyne

No way... (silently)

(coughs) Are we interrupting something?

Felicidad

(takes her head off of RAFAEL's shoulders and both FELICIDAD and RAFAEL stand up)

Oh...We-...Um-...

Rafael

Oh hey you guys... I guess we're not hiding anymore.

(RAFAEL laughs as he shrugs his shoulders and grabs FELICIDAD's hand and shows them)

Jethro

About time.

(dabs up RAFAEL)

Krystyne

Took you guys long enough. We've been placing bets since freshman year!

Felicidad

Oh my god, did you guys really!?

Jethro

Oh, we absolutely did.

(smirking and nodding his head)

Rafael

Guess it wasn't that subtle, huh?

(grabs IDA's hand)

Krystyne

Subtle? Please. It was giving Kathniel before they confirmed they were actually together.

Jethro

Why do you always have to bring that couple up all the time?

Krystyne

Cause I can?

Jethro

Okay bro... Anyways, since we're all here, I wanted to invite you guys to my Hip-Hop performance tomorrow.

Krystyne

Count me in!

Rafael

Us too!

(looks over at FELICIDAD)

Jethro

Alright bet! I'll send more details in our group chat. Krys lets finish out our last lap?

Krystyne

Ughhhh, okayyyy.

(KRYSTYNE and JP start jogging off stage)

Oh and also! We want front-row seats at the wedding by the way!

[the light only shines on FELICIDAD and RAFAEL as they start packing up the picnic to go home]

Felicidad

Wedding!? We literally stopped hiding 30 minutes ago.

(laughs)

Rafael

Yeah...

(he looks at her and stops packing up)

But for the first time, I'm not scared of what comes next.

(continues to pack up)

Felicidad

Me neither.

(continues to pack up, and then looks at RAFAEL)

So...what do we call this?

Rafael

Magic?

(they laugh softly and pick up everything to leave)

Felicidad

You finally believe in it?

Rafael

Only when I'm with you.

(grabs her hand and starts walking off stage)

Felicidad

Then let's not waste it.

(both walk off stage and the lights dim slowly as they walk off)

END OF SCENE - BLACKOUT

Scene 7 : CLASHROOM

Setting: | The classroom.

At Rise: | Krys and JP sit behind Raf and Ida. They are looking at their computers on their desks as they wait for Reyes to come in.

Reyes

(walks into classroom and puts things down)

Good afternoon, everyone.

(brief response from the class)

Before we begin...I wanted to address something.

(pause)

It has come to my attention that some students enrolled in this course expected Professor Baculanta to teach it.

(KRYSTYNE slowly turns her head toward JP. RAFAEL goes still)

Reyes (cont.)

And that my presence here has been...well, for a lack of better words, a disappointment.

(beat)

If there are concerns about my qualifications or curriculum, I would prefer they be expressed directly in this classroom.

Not...externally.

(she avoids looking at JP)

Krystyne

(quietly, but firm)

Externally? What do you mean?

(beat)

Who told you that?

Reyes

That isn't the point.

Rafael

(leaning forward)

It actually is. Because we didn't file a complaint.

Reyes

I didn't say you filed a complaint.

(KRYS looks at JP)

Krystyne

JP.

(beat)

(JP exhales)

Jethro

I didn't mean for it to—

Rafael

(standing up)

You told her?

Marc

(stepping forward slightly)

Rafael—

Rafael

(sits down)

No. Let him answer.

Jethro

I told her the energy wasn't personal.

That you all thought Professor Baculanta would be teaching.

That's it.

Felicidad

(arms crossed, shaking her head)

That's not "it," JP.

Jethro

I was trying to help.

Rafael

Help who?

Jethro

The class!

(frustrated)

You think the university is just waiting for this to succeed? It took years to even get this class to be a thing.

Rafael

So you decided to protect the professor from us?

Jethro

No! I decided to protect the class - the program we helped build!

(students continue to argue)

Marc

(looks at REYES while pointing at the students)

This is getting out of hand Professor Reyes.

(looks at students)

Everyone, please-

Reyes

(frustrated)

Everyone, please. Settle down!

(students go silent)

Marc

We are obviously mixing three different conflicts here. Expectation, representation, and trust.

Reyes

We are in a professional classroom setting, let me remind everyone that we are here to learn about the material.

Rafael

(ignoring MARC as he looks at JP)

Why didn't you think to tell us how you felt JP?

Jethro

When would I?

(becoming more frustrated)

When you're mid-speech about colonial frameworks? Or when you're correcting her pronunciation like she's your student?

(RAFAEL recoils)

Rafael

You think I enjoy doing that?

You think I want to be that guy?

Jethro

Then why does it feel like you do?

Krystyne

JP...we were fighting for representation.

Jethro

And what about me?

(honest)

(moves to the front of the classroom)

You talk about Mindanao.

You talk about indigenous roots.

You talk about oral histories passed down from your grandparents.

I don't have that.

(beat)

I'm half Filipino.

My Tagalog is broken.

Most of the time I'm Google translating Tagalog words under the table so I don't look stupid.

This class?

Even if it's basic to you?

It's not basic to me.

It's the first time I don't feel behind.

Rafael

(stands up)

So we don't push for better because you're comfortable?

Jethro

It's not about comfort!

It's about not feeling like I'm failing my own culture every time you open your mouth!

(silence)

Marc

Okay- hey. Hold on.

(he steps between JP and RAFAEL slightly but not blocking. He looks between them)

You two are not even arguing about the same thing right now.

(beat)

Rafael - you're talking about being erased.

Jethro - you're talking about not feeling like you belong at all.

(beat)

That's not the same fight.

Rafael

(steady, hurt)

You think I don't know what invisibility feels like?

Do you know how many times Filipinos from Luzon push my people to the side?

Representation isn't ego.

It's survival.

Jethro

And being biracial isn't confusion.

It's isolation.

(silence)

Reyes

(steps forward, trying to regain control)

Okay everyone, just-

(both JP and RAFAEL sit back down)

(stops herself, recalibrates, and exhales)

Reyes (cont.)

We are not going to turn this into people talking over each other.

(beat)

If you have something to say, you say it clearly. One at a time.

(she looks directly at the students)

This is still a classroom. (sternly)

Felicidad

(softening)

JP...we never meant to make you feel less Filipino.

Jethro

You didn't have to mean it.

(beat)

You all walk in like you already know everything. I walk in hoping I don't get exposed.

Reyes

(quiet - finally understanding)

No one in this room should feel like they have to prove they belong here.

(beat)

That includes you.

(JP looks up, but doesn't respond)

Rafael

(quiet but frustrated)

So we just...what?

Ignore what's wrong?

Marc

No.

(quick, grounded)

We don't ignore it.

(looks at REYES faulty)

(pauses and looks at students)

But we don't tear everything down to fix it either.

There's a difference between pushing something forward and breaking it.

Krystyne

(looking at JP)

You should've trusted us.

Jethro

You should've seen me.

(silence)

Reyes

That's enough.

(beat)

We are not resolving this all at once. And we are definitely not resolving it by turning on each other.

(she looks around the room)

Reyes (cont.)

From what I know...this class exists because you all fought for it.

(beat)

So we're going to act like it matters.

(silence)

Reyes (cont.)

Class is dismissed. We will return to the curriculum when we can return to each other.

[General classroom lights widen slightly]

(students stand up to pack their bags except for JP. RAFAEL grabs his bag immediately)

Rafael

(speaking to JP angrily)

You don't get to speak for us.

Jethro

And you don't get to decide what makes someone Filipino enough.

(RAFAEL exits)

(FELICIDAD hesitates, then follows)

(KRYSTYNE lingers)

Krystyne

(soft)

I didn't know.

Jethro

You didn't ask.

(KRYSTYNE nods and exits. JP looks back to his computer)

Marc

(approaches JP. JP looks up at him from his computer)

You were trying to keep things from falling apart.

(beat)

That doesn't make you wrong. I hope you know that.

(beat)

But it does put you in the middle of everything.

(laughs ironically)

Marc (cont.)

I heard Sparta Philippines Hip-Hop has a performance tonight. Are you in it?

(JP nods)

Well, don't carry all of this into that. Just show up as you are. You're doing great JP.

(beat)

Being in this class...being a part of the Filipino club...that doesn't make you any less Filipino. If anything...some may say it makes you more.

(both laugh)

Jethro

Thanks, Marc. I really appreciate it.

(MARC exits)

(JP looks at his computer)

Marc (cont.)

Of course. Break a leg out there.

(fistbumps JP but JP weakly give him a fistbump)

(REYES lingers a second - almost says something to JP, then doesn't. she exits STAGE LEFT)

QUICK BLACKOUT

Jethro

(pulls out his phone calling his friends)

(softly and frustrated, to himself)

Ugh. Why are they not answering!? Maybe they're just late.

(the dancers take formation behind him)

(he looks out one last time)

(nothing)

(he nods to himself)

(looks frustrated at his phone)

Dancer

Yo JP, you ready?

(JP doesn't answer immediately. He scans the audience again and puts his phone away)

(searching left, then right)

(he takes a breath and swallows)

Jethro

(quiet, holding it together)

Yea.

(steps into first position in the front)

QUICK BLACKOUT AND CHANGE OF LIGHTS

END SCENE 7

MODERN HIP HOP PERFORMANCE

BLACKOUT

Scene 8 : FESTIVAL

Setting: | Baculanta's office and FIST-201 classroom, a week later. An announcement is made that they will be going on a FieldTrip to a festival in Filipino Town.

At Rise: | The classroom stage right, Baculanta's office stage left.

[LIGHT FOCUSES ON STAGE LEFT (BACULANTA'S OFFICE)]

(REYES knocks)

Baculanta

Come in.

(REYES enters)

Reyes

(she hesitates before speaking)

Do you have a minute?

Baculanta

(looking at her carefully, as she prompts for REYES to sit down)

Marie, hello! Yes, I do.

(REYES slowly and sits)

Reyes

(with a sad and frustrated tone)

The room is split. Physically.

Front row. Back row.

The class isn't fighting anymore.

They've just...stopped talking.

(beat)

I lost them.

Baculanta

And you're surprised?

Reyes

No.

(beat)

I mean...yes. I thought if I was clear, it would settle things. Instead, it made everything worse.

(beat)

Now when I walk in, they don't look at each other.

Now, simple discussion feels... forced

Baculanta

I see... last time we talked, I told you you should consider their ideas into what you teach.

(beat)

But I see now...now you have a bigger problem. A problem much more beyond us professors.

Reyes

Adding new content to the class like some wanted will not fix the classroom anymore.

(beat)

I need help. Please Franchesca, you know these students better than I do.

(looks at BACULANTA desperately)

Baculanta

Okay...Hmmm...

(scrolls through her computer and pretends to type)

Take them out of the classroom. Take them on a field trip.

Reyes

A field trip?

Baculanta

Yes. A field trip.

(flips computer for REYES to see and points at it)

There's a Filipino festival happening later this week.

They need a change of scenery.

They need to be reminded of why they took this class in the first place.

Reyes

I see where you're going with this.

It'll let them experience something together without needing to defend themselves.

(beat)

(lightbulb moment)

If they're there - actually engaging with people, not just material-

Baculanta

(finishes REYES's sentence)

- then they're not stuck in that setup they don't want anymore.

(beat)

You need to let them experience their culture firsthand.

Reyes

...Okay.

(with a certain tone)

I'll get Marc to take them.

I will let them figure things out while they're there.

(stands up)

I hope this works!

Baculanta

Ako din, Marie.

Reyes

Salamat, Franchesca.

(both smile)

[LIGHTS FADE STAGE LEFT]

Classroom – Later That Week

Reyes

Okay, before we start...

(beat)

I need to address something.

Last week, I reacted very defensively, causing things to escalate very quickly.

That's on me, and I take full accountability.

(the room is quiet but attentive)

Reyes (cont.)

This course was designed to survive departmental approval. Not necessarily to reflect the full range of Filipino experience. There is a difference.

Rafael

(steady)

So what changes?

Reyes

We go somewhere that isn't a classroom. On Friday we're attending the community cultural festival in Filipino Town. We will be volunteering. You will all be talking to performers, organizers, and elders. And afterward, we revise our final presentations to reflect what we actually learned. Not just what was printed.

Marc will be chaperoning this field trip, so please be prepared to tell me all the experiences and knowledge you encountered during the next class session.

Reyes (cont.)

This class cannot feel like one narrative defending itself against another. If it does, it fails.

(beat)

And I am not interested in failing.

[JP glances back briefly. RAFAEL sees it but says nothing]

[BLACKOUT]

Cultural Festival

[warm outdoor lighting rises. festival sounds fill the space: drums, chatter, laughter]

[the cardboard bus rolls in playfully from STAGE RIGHT. students mime stepping off]

Marc

Okay everyone, thanks for being here today! I hope ya'll enjoy the festival. Here are the assignments.

(MARC distributes clipboards)

Raf and Ida — main stage support.

Krys and JP — Lumagen booth documentation.

(KRYSTYNE and JP exchange a small, tense look and move STAGE LEFT to Lumagen Booth)

Lumagen Booth (Stage Left)

Jethro

(points at Lumagen booth)

You've never talked about this one much.

Krystyne

Because it's not the kind people usually ask about.

It's not flashy.

It doesn't fit the neat narratives.

(beat)

It's older than all the stuff we argue about.

(laughs awkwardly)

Jethro

I'm sorry.

(beat)

Krystyne

For which part?

Jethro

For not telling you how I felt. And for telling Reyes instead. I didn't think she'd bring it up in class like that.

Krystyne

I know you didn't. But it still felt like you picked a side.

Jethro

I wasn't picking a side. I was trying to keep the class from exploding.

Krystyne

It exploded anyway.

(beat)

You should've trusted us.

Jethro

I was embarrassed.

(beat)

When you guys talk about regions and oral histories, I feel like everyone else got a handbook on how to be Filipino and I didn't.

Krystyne

JP, we all know that there isn't a handbook.

Jethro

It feels like there is.

Being biracial is weird.

You're too Filipino in some rooms.

Not Filipino enough in others.

So when I finally felt like I understood the syllabus—

(beat)

I didn't want it torn apart.

Krystyne

We weren't tearing you or the class apart.

Jethro

It felt like it.

(beat)

I don't want to compete for authenticity.

Krystyne

Then don't.

(softly)

You don't have to know everything to belong.

Just...let us know how you're feeling next time.

(JP nods slowly)

We're your friends DUHHH.

Don't make me feel like a potato. I can do so much more, you know?

(both laugh)

Jethro

Looks like the Lumagen Performance is starting soon!

BLACKOUT

LUMAGEN PERFORMANCE

(RAFAEL and FELICIDAD start talking from STAGE RIGHT)

Rafael

(quietly)

This is what I was trying to explain.

(beat)

It's not...put together for us.

It's not filtered.

It just exists.

Felicidad

Yeah

(beat)

It feels different.

Rafael

Exactly.

(beat)

I think I came in too strong.

Ida

You've been protective because you cared.

(beat)

I don't see anything wrong with that.

(looks at RAFAEL and rubs his shoulder)

(RAFAEL and FELICIDAD glances over at JP and KRYSTYNE talking)

Marc

Okay, everyone! Gather up!

(students regroup center stage where MARC is)

[music fades and festival sounds soften]

Marc

What did you learn today that wasn't in the packet?

Rafael

That we've been looking at it too narrowly. There are dances even older than the categories we know.

Krystyne

That some traditions don't fit colonial documentation.

Jethro

That belonging isn't a test.

(He says it without looking at Raf.)

Felicidad

And...that we don't all come into this the same way.

(everyone looks up at one another)

Rafael

(quiet, honest)

Yeah.

(beat)

Jethro

But we're still here.

(looks at Raf)

Together.

Marc

(smiles and nods—very satisfied with the reconciliation of the friend group)

Good.

(beat)

Hold onto that.

(looks at everyone and stops at JP)

Now JP, how about you end us off with a little historical background on Lumagen. You were assigned at the booth after all.

Jethro

(proudly speaking)

Well...from being at the Lumagen Booth and looking at some documents, I learned a lot actually!

(beat)

The dance comes from pre-colonial Indigenous traditions, longggg before Spanish influence. It's not really... built for performance the way we're used to seeing. It's more about community - moving together, keeping rhythm together.

Marc

(nods, satisfied but grounded)

Exactly. And that's just as important.

(looks at all of them)

Alright! (claps) - lets start heading back to campus.

(everyone starts walking off STAGE RIGHT but RAFAEL and JP walk slower and are spotlighted)

Rafael

Are you performing for Sparta Philippines on Friday?

Jethro

Yeah, I am.

Rafael

Don't mess up the timing.

(daps JP up and they both laugh)

[Lights dim slowly]

END OF SCENE 8

BLACKOUT

Scene 9 : IN SOLIDARITY

Setting: | A stage.

At Rise: | Traditional tinikling sticks start at beginning formation. Background characters in the back talking.

(JP stands downstage. He stretches his hands once, shakes them out. He does not look toward the audience.)

Dancer

You good JP?

Jethro

Yeah.

(beat)

Let's just do it.

(he keeps looking forward and doesn't look into the crowd)

[music builds, the dancers take formation]

[Lights flash to blackout, then rise to warm post-performance glow]

MODERN TINIK PERFORMANCE

[warm lights start to glow the whole stage with JP in the middle]

Krystyne

(from offstage, with a poster)

JP!

(he looks at the audience)

(KRYSTYNE, RAFAEL, and FELICIDAD run and come up the stairs and go onto stage)

What's up, our favorite ABB! You were so great up there!

(hugs JP)

Jethro

(softly)

You guys came.

Krystyne

Of course we came.

Felicidad

Did you really think we wouldn't?

Jethro

(half-smile)

Last time you didn't.

(laughs softly)

(RAFAEL steps forward)

Rafael

Yeah, we're sorry.

(beat)

That was on us.

I was still angry. And I let that be louder than...everything else.

(beat)

But I watched tonight. You weren't dancing to prove anything. You were just...dancing.

Jethro

I didn't look out there.

Rafael

I noticed.

Jethro

I didn't want to know if you guys weren't here.

Felicidad

Aw...JP...

Jethro

Last time I kept looking. I kept hoping. And when you weren't there it felt like I messed up twice. Once in class. And once on stage.

Rafael

You didn't mess up in class. You were being truthful and cared about the class.

Jethro

I shouldn't have told her.

Rafael

Maybe not. But I shouldn't have made you feel like you were less Filipino for defending the part you understood.

(beat)

That wasn't fair.

Jethro

When I talk about...anything, it sounds like I'm Googling.

Krystyne

You're not Googling. You're building off what we're learning. That's different.

Felicidad

And honestly? None of us know everything. We just sound confident.

(shrugs her shoulders and everyone laughs)

Rafael

Please don't hide these emotions from us anymore. Call us out if you feel uncomfortable JP.

Jethro

You mean that?

Rafael

Yeah.

(beat)

And next time I feel unheard, I'll talk to you first, not argue.

Jethro

I'll do the same.

(strong dab up and hug)

[From the side of the stage, BACULANTA, REYES, and MARC step forward. They've been watching]

Baculanta

That was powerful.

Reyes

(looking at JP)

You didn't dilute anything.

You didn't choose between traditional and modern.

You made space for both.

JP

(half-grin)

Yea. I guess I found a middle through dance.

Marc

I'm glad you did, JP.

(beat)

It's always important to find a middle ground.

(beat)

Professors have a surprise for you all.

(gestures towards both professors)

Baculanta

We've been talking about the future of the class...

(JP and the others look up)

Reyes

And next semester... this class won't look the same.

Rafael

Different how?

Reyes

We're co-teaching.

(beat)

Krystyne

Wait. Actually?

Baculanta

Actually.

Reyes

One syllabus. Built together.

With input from the Filipino Student Organization - Sparta Philippines.

Baculanta

Rural Suite. Maria Clara. Singkil. Lumagen. Diaspora identity. Community practicum. All of it.

Reyes

And... we will add a study abroad component to further deepen cultural knowledge.

(glances towards MARC)

Marc will be chaperoning the Philippines trip as part of the class requirements.

Krystynne

O-M-G! Philippines trip!

(brings hands up while KRYSTYNE jumps)

(everyone laughs)

Felicidad

So...no more safe syllabus?

Reyes

No more hiding behind a safe syllabus.

Baculanta

And no more treating disagreement like disruption.

(RAFAEL looks at JP)

Rafael

Guess we started something.

Jethro

Guess we did.

Reyes

(looking at JP)

You said in class that belonging shouldn't feel like a test. I've been thinking about that.

(beat)

Belonging shouldn't feel like a prerequisite either.

Baculanta

Identity is not something you pass or fail. It is something you practice. Together.

Krystynne

So what now?

Rafael

Now?

(RAFAEL looks at JP)

We show up.

Jethro

Yeah, we show up.

In solidarity.

(everyone hugs)

(REYES looks at BACULANTA)

[Lights rise to full glow]

[they all bow]

[Blackout]

END OF PLAY